



Photo: NRC/Adrienne Surprenant

Miglo carries the wood, fabric and cords necessary to build her tent. From her 200 goats, nothing is left. Somalia experienced its worst drought in 20 years, following two consecutive seasons of poor rainfall.

SOMALIA | Emergency response to drought and displacement

Somalia remained one of the world's longest standing aid operations. The impact of such a long-drawn humanitarian situation is well known; over 73 per cent of the population lived below the poverty line (\$1.25 per day) in 2016. Half the population needed humanitarian assistance and livelihoods support. Over one million people were displaced within the country, while over 1.2 million were refugees in the Horn of Africa and Yemen.

The humanitarian situation in Somalia rapidly deteriorated over the last year as one of the most severe droughts in history hit the country and renewed famine became a strong possibility. Two consecutive seasons of insufficient rainfall brought a severe drought. The country lacked mechanisms to harvest and conserve run-off water even when flooding occurred. The price of livestock declined rapidly and livestock died in large numbers. As a result, communities were forced to sell their assets and borrow money to survive.

Humanitarian access remained difficult with high levels of insecurity in most districts of southern and central Somalia. This impeded needs assessments, delivering humanitarian supplies and response monitoring.

Food security and livelihoods

Cash-based programmes constituted more than 80 per cent of NRC's food security programmes, including

conditional and unconditional cash transfers and cash for work projects. NRC provided between 70 and 100 percent of the minimum expenditure basket of each region.

The transfer procedures relied on criteria by the Integrated Phase Classification (IPC phase) of the targeted community, as well as available coping mechanisms within the household or community. This prevented erosion of acceptable coping mechanisms and creation of dependency. Conditional cash transfer beneficiaries gained practical skills from training related to small-scale business, nutrition and child feeding practices, and environmental conservation awareness.

Shelter

Although Protection Reporting and Monitoring Network's reported some improvements, shelter needs remained high with over 77,000 people newly displaced by droughts by the end of the year, on top of 300,000 conflict-related internally displaced people.

Shelter programming provided emergency assistance to some 14,000 newly displaced people affected by drought, conflict or evictions.

NRC provided culturally appropriate owner-driven transitional shelters to stabilised settlements with improved temporary land tenure of 5-10 years in Puntland, Somaliland and South and Central Somalia.

NRC negotiated access to land and facilitated secure land tenure for internally displaced people. This was part of our effort to address conflict-induced displacement and forced evictions.

This reached close to 10,000 people almost half of whom were women and girls.

As part of the cross-border return programme from Kenya, NRC supported the shelter of 450 returnee, IDP and host community families in Baidoa, Dollow, Galkayo, Garowe, Kismayo and Luuq.

Water, sanitation and hygiene

The failure of two consecutive rains resulted in severe drought that significantly reduced water sources, sharply increased water prices and increased water-borne infections. Responding to the crisis, NRC deployed water trucking and established water extension pipelines. Construction of latrines helped to extend hygiene promotion awareness in affected communities.

NRC constructed and rehabilitated more than 60 water sources. Family shared latrines provided hygiene facilities for almost 24,000 people as part of our work to enhance public health and prevent cholera outbreaks.

The installation of a solar-powered submersible pump helped reduce water collection hours while increasing output. NRC rehabilitated shallow wells and water troughs. Over 115,000 people, including some 56,000 women and children benefitted from water, sanitation and hygiene support in Somalia.

Education

In Puntland, Somaliland and South Central Somalia, NRC's education programme increased access to basic education and vocational training as a fundamental human right for all children and youth. This served as a social protection tool for displaced

people, returnees and children from hard-to-reach communities. Education significantly contributed to conflict resolution among displaced people, returnees and host community members.

NRC worked with local authorities to ensure that the adopted curriculum addressed learners' needs. Teacher training enhanced quality learning for children. Accreditation procedures ensured the provision of recognised certificates for completed levels, enabling learners to document their achievements to continue schooling or enhance their future job opportunities.

Information, counselling and legal assistance (ICLA)

NRC collaborated with UNHCR, UN Habitat and universities in Puntland and Hargeisa, to provide expert technical support to develop housing, land and property (HLP) capacity in Somaliland and Puntland. By continuously taking steps to protect rights of displaced communities for housing, land and property, NRC facilitated sustainable recovery among vulnerable communities and promoted durable solutions.

NRC negotiated access to land and facilitated secure land tenure for internally displaced people and refugee returnees in Baidoa, Galkayo, Kismayo and Luuq. This was part of our efforts to address conflict-induced secondary displacements and forced evictions.

In conflict resolution and information dissemination, NRC piloted a unique humanitarian programme that combined traditional community sensitisation techniques, community outreach, and standard social dialogue skills.

RETURNED TO SOMALIA FROM DADAAB



In 2002, Amina fled Somalia together with her nine children to escape clan conflict. They crossed the border into Kenya, and arrived in the Dadaab refugee camp. Afterward her husband died. Amina raised her children and supported her family alone. She lost two of her children while in Dadaab.

Amina later left the refugee camp and returned to Somalia. She was among thousands of returnees who were trying to rebuild their lives in Somalia after leaving the refugee camp. After spending 14 years living as a refugee, the decision to return to Somalia with her seven children was a difficult one. Although she left of her own will, life became increasingly uncertain and challenging.

“My son was arrested twice during night patrols by the police, they suspected him of being a member of Al-Shabaab,” said Amina.

She saved some money from her son’s work at an ice factory and sold half her monthly food ration to generate enough money to travel back to Somalia. On return to Somalia, she settled in Balad-Hawa. A high presence of militia groups made her feel unsafe. So she moved further north to Dollow.

Supported by the UK Department for International Development, NRC is helping returnees to integrate locally. A housing, land and property cross-border programme provides information and cross-border referrals to enable returnees reclaim their assets upon return. Together with other returnees in Dollow, Amina is now a participant in NRC’s cash-for-work initiative.

“Dadaab was a good place; we had free food and water. When I first came to Dollow, I struggled to find support. Fortunately, my living conditions are better now. I feel safer and I am able to look for work. I am a traditional birth attendant, and I am helping women giving birth to the next generation,” says Amina.